

St. John's College High School

2026



Literary Magazine

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Front Cover

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Julia Andrews '26

Olivia Aquino '27

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Back Cover

Meliah Haynes '27

Chair On the Hill - Leandro Navas '26

The sun shines, birds sing.

Chair on the hill, pen in hand,

feeling all the love.

Writing all my thoughts,

feeling God's peace around me,

the sun sets, birds rest.

As I end the day,

I feel God's love in my way.

Now it's time to pray.

Victory Jones '27



Faith — Christian Larson '26

Sunday morning, 6:45 my alarm begins to ring.
Time to rise, time to dress, time to put on my best.

I walk into the church with my mom beside me,
the doors opening to only hear a screech.

I stand. I kneel. I sit.
Sometimes just moving with the motions,
mind wandering through the repeated,
hearing, not necessarily listening.

An hour passes.
An hour filled with drifting thoughts,
with hopes, questions, dreams that fixate me.

I've understood that faith isn't only found
in prayers spoken in repentance
or in perfect attention.

Faith is something quieter
something happening inside,
shaping itself in the places no one else sees.

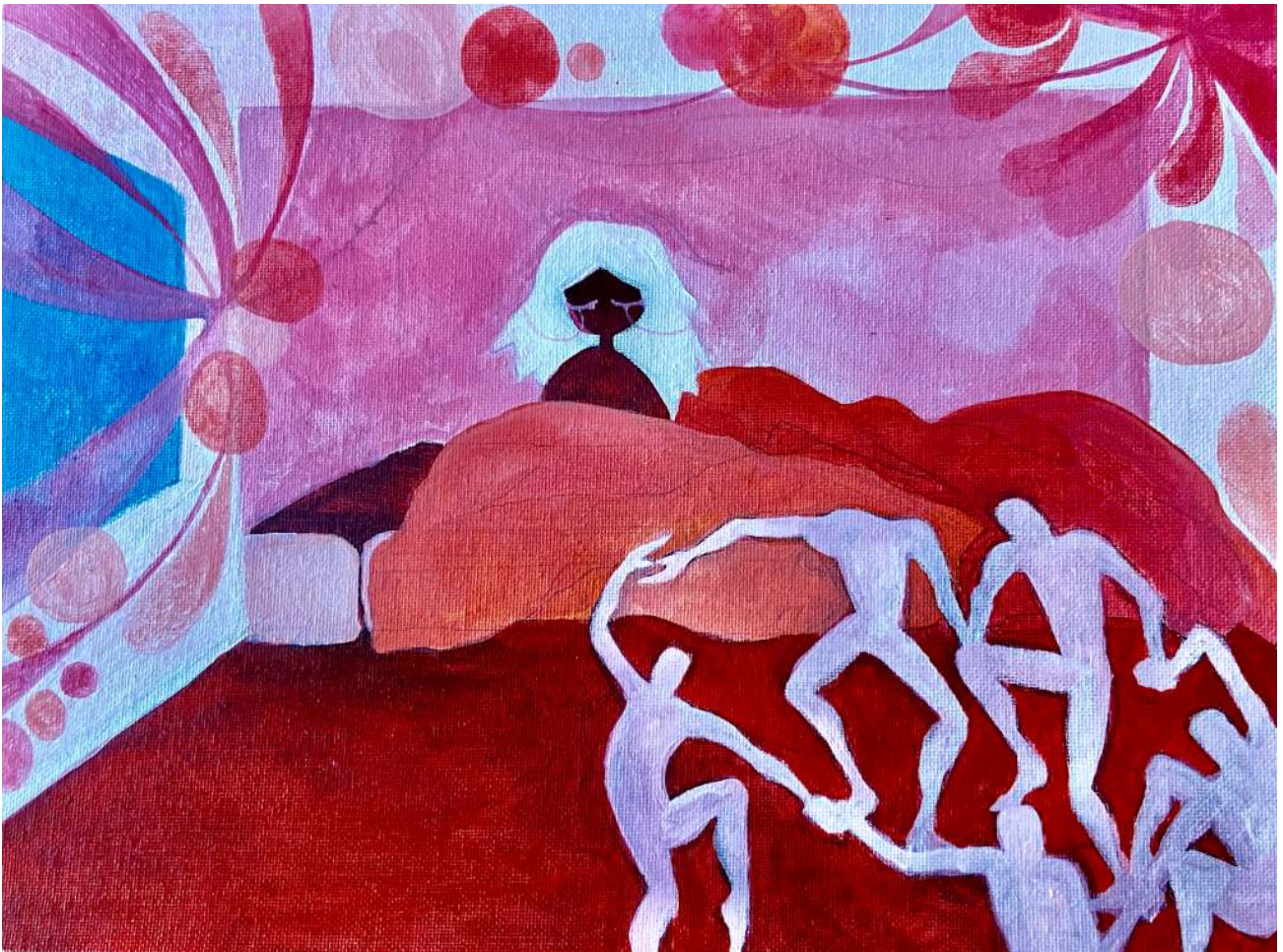
You are faith,
and faith is already within you.

So think, and rejoice.
Let your thoughts be free.
Let your heart open in its own way.

For faith lives not just in the pews,
but in the wandering.

Molly Bromley '27





Olivia Aquino '27

The Bright Pink Cowboy Boots — Reagan Tymon '26

Once I was a girl with bright pink cowboy boots.
 A girl too scared to talk, too scared to be.
 One who wanted so much, but had so little.
 She did not know where to start or where to begin.
 I was a dreamer.

Now I have the dream.
 I see where I once was.
 Lost, unseen, unheard,
 she's not me.

Although I am the same bright pink cowgirl,
 people look up to me,
 but I hear, see, and understand,
 the people who were once me.
 Now I am the girl I would have looked up to.
 I am the girl I always wanted to be.

Jacob Cruz '27



What a Teenage Dream — Olivia Foster '29

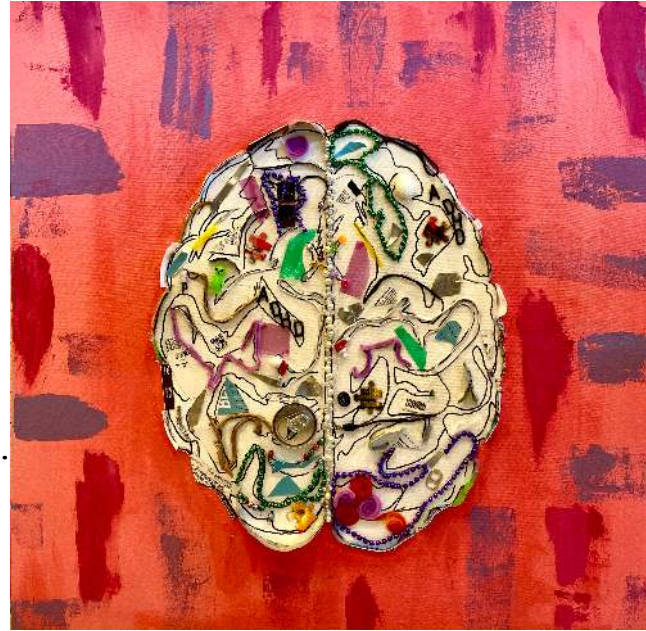
The teenage dream isn't always what you think.
There are lots and lots of tears, then over in a blink.
Though the pressure and drama will get you,
And the grades and social life will forever be eschew.
The rush it is to feel the adrenaline of a game,
Or ready for the dance, dressed perfectly and hair tamed.
Late nights and cries that always end in amends.
To be dying for a breath, laughing with your friends.
First days of school, and the summer days spent in the sun.
Being alone with thoughts and music, just wanting to have fun.
Trying something new, then becomes the favorite routine.
These are the joys of a teen.
It will be hard and rough,
The days will be long, and you'll become tough.
Yet what privilege it is to be,
A happy kid, wild and free.

Thaddeus Shaffer '27



Nostalgia – Allison Felluca '27

Warming rays of sunlight drift through memories,
Faded pictures flicker like butterfly wings.
I hear old laughter echo back, ha ha,
Like waves returning to a quiet shore.
Friendships bounce like loopy loops of shoelaces,
Springing with every step, full of quiet joy.
Playdates and promises drifting through time,
Sweet smiles gleam beneath bright, playful sunlight.
Soft sounds of stories circle round my thoughts,
Nostalgia hums like a gentle hummingbird,
It wraps my heart in a comfort blanket,
Grief tiptoes softly, leaving shadows behind.
Laughter folds into sighs along expressionless grass.
Sunlight spills warm across the glittery scales grass,
Splash, splash, the sprinkler sprays bursts of laughter.



Reagan Tymon '26

Hope is Sneaky – Austin Mitchell '29

Sometimes the sky is gray and glum,
like the sun forgot to come.
But peek behind the clouds and you'll see,
it's shining there for you and me.
The trees still sway and kids still play,
even on a cloudy day.
The wind might blow, the rain might pour,
but that never stops the fun outdoors.
Hope is sneaky, quiet, small,
it hides and laughs with joy for all.
A song, a joke, a bright balloon,
it turns the gray into a tune.
Sunshine wins, it always does,
and it will find you just because.

Elsa Kerr '29



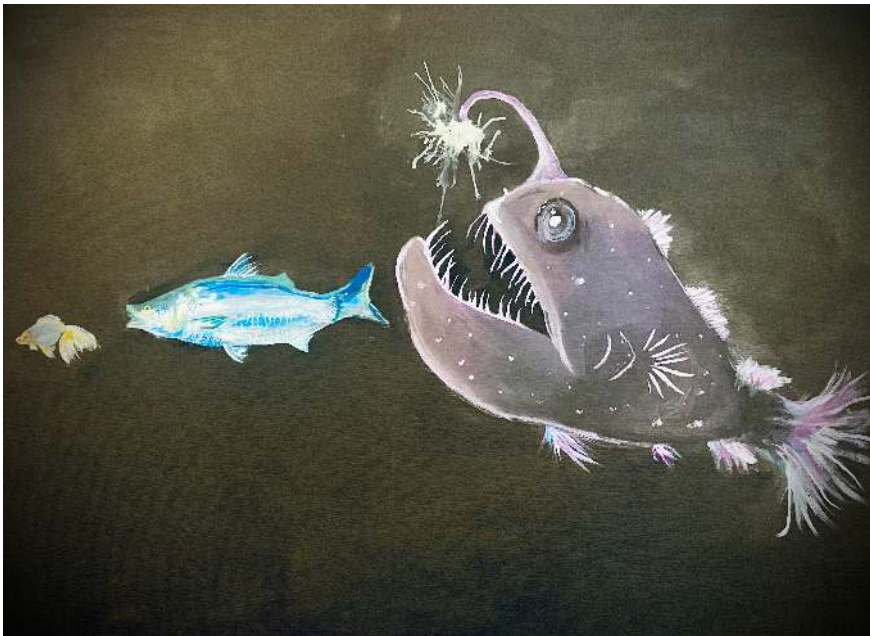
I Feel the Fear — Reagan Tymon '26

I Feel the Fear.
The anxiety of the next paper,
the next notification.
That paralyzing feeling,
being glued to the News,
being glued to the screen.
I Feel the Fear.
Are these fears ever going to...
Stop?
When will the bad news...
Stop?
Will it ever...
Stop?
I Feel the Fear.
I Fear the Fear.



Lucy Crain '27

Layla Tamiz '27



Night — Kay McIntyre '29

Tired eyes watch the skies,
Blooming over the park.
The day's begun once the sun,
Repaints the nighttime's dark.
One would think of this pink,
As morning's best flower.
But the time of it's prime,
Is an ungodly hour.



Giulia Ibi '26

The Peace We Keep — Bemnet Yiesak '26

When the warm days begin to fade into cold,
 a new time of mercy begins to unfold,
 and the heart finds its steady hold.
 Blessed Mary, with blossoms of pure red and white,
 a sign of sincere love, a beacon of light.
 Her love blooms, so clear and bright,
 in the cold season, she brings to us the light.

Our reverent songs are sweet and proud,
 offering love, drawing souls near.
 Calling her to us, to deliver us with her mercy
 at the right hand of the light.
 When the Earth is quiet and still,
 it waits for its beauty to fill.
 Christ, our beaming gift,
 helps lift our weighty hearts.
 So let us gather, in this time of disarray,
 with St. Mary's light, our guide.
 For even in winter, resounding and cruel,
 the promise of new life is what we must keep.

Ava Boza '26



Between Two Homes – Annabel Bonner Garcia '29

I used to draw one home
with red bricks and blue shutters,
a whole family inside:
me, my sister, my mom, and my dad
together.

Now I draw two.

One smells like my dad's cereal and fruit,
the other like my mom's lavender candles.

Both say they love me,
but never at the same time.

I pack my backpack
with clothes, homework,
and everything in between.

My mom says, "Don't forget your charger,"
and my dad says,
"glad you're back, it makes my heart larger."

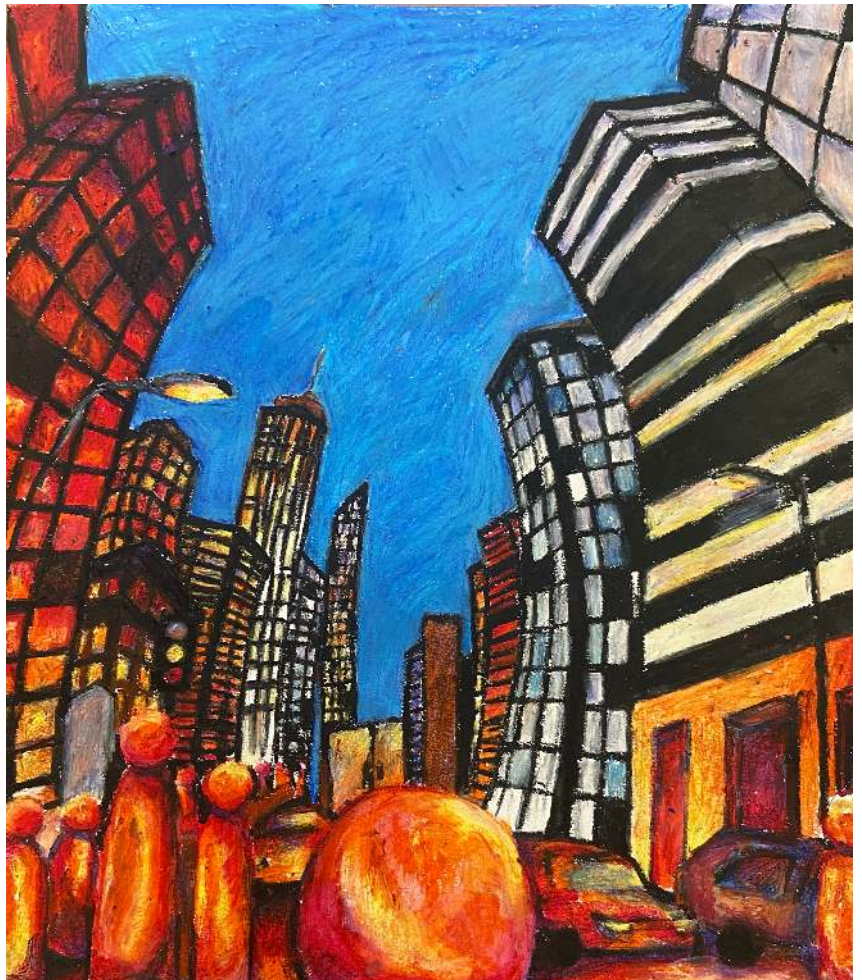
This family used to be one
now it's split in two.

I always wonder
if love can be split in the middle,
each person leaving
their half behind.

I live in that middle,
between doors,
between houses,
between hearts
that used to beat together.

I live in that middle,
learning that two homes
can still hold one heart.

Giulia Ibi '26



Shells Hold Memories — Delena Negussie '26

We left the pink conch on the vendor's stand,
I wanted treasure held in my own hand,
the hunt itself, not something bought and planned.

Now marked with Sharpie, each initial scrawled
holds in its curve a memory, recalled
and gifted so a shared joy is installed.

For nostalgia is Twister on the floor,
a Just Dance marathon, cousins, and more,
two a.m. talks outside a bedroom door.

It's heart-to-hearts that never fully end,
a laughter you can somehow still depend
on, like a memory you can re-lend.

The shell I found, the conversations deep,
are treasures that I gather up and keep,
not buried, but to stir from restless sleep.

The child who hunted shells along the tide
still seeks the light that others pass beside,
and finds the past held closely, glorified.

Annie Pierson '26

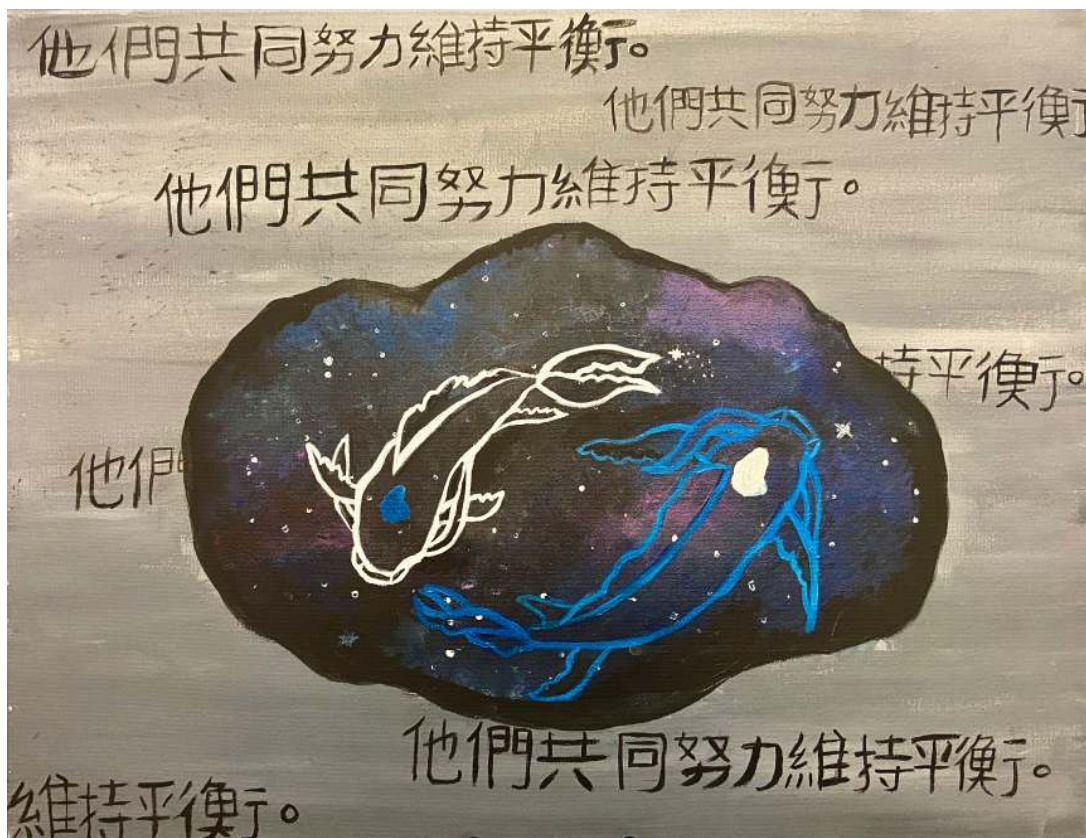


On a Beach Somewhere

— Aziza Kennedy '26

Teenage years are nice, but I sometimes - impatiently - dream of being old. I envision this moment where I will be sitting on a beach, with my legs straight out in front of me, my arms slightly behind my back, and my palms flat against the warm sand. I will not be in America, but instead maybe in Portugal or Belgium or Sweden. It will be late evening and it will be dark. Not pitch black. It will be the soft, light blue that makes every distant figure turn into a dark silhouette. I will wonder, as I often do, how such a light-colored sky can produce such dark lighting, when it is darker than the medium-blue sky of day. Or maybe I will know by then. I will have a sense of wisdom to me. I will be confident in myself and what I can handle - a different type of confidence than I had at 15, or 22, or 40. I will observe the repetitive forming and crashing of the waves and still notice the differences there are in each. Maybe they are each different because of the wind? I'm not sure. But I will be then. I will reflect on all of the people I have met and try my hardest not to summarize them into the simple categories of my mind. I will watch the clouds fade and the moon emerge, creating a mesmerizing shimmer on the black sea. I will get lost in the depths of my thoughts. I will wonder how I moved on from difficult things and how unable I am, at this moment, at this age, to have regrets. I will sigh and chuckle to myself thinking about how tired I feel in my arms, in my legs. I will reminisce about the things that I will never be able to do again and will never have to do again. I will reflect on all of the moments where I was overwhelmed or joyful while surrounded by people, and also the calm, thriving moments of solitude. I will sit there on this beach, old and alone, and I will simply be.





Julia Andrews '26

hide. You don't rush toward me or shout my name; You just keep rocking, patient, waiting for me to come home. When I finally reach the steps, You smile gently with that knowing look, you don't ask where I've been or why I wandered so far. You pat the chair next to You and say, "Rest a bit." The blanket already folded over the rocker, the mug of tea You poured before I even arrived, the way You tilt Your head so I know You're listening. That's the kind of caring that tells me I don't have to be strong or perfect to be welcomed. You care for me like a father who knows every version of me: the child who ran barefoot through the house causing havoc, the teenager who slammed doors and cried into her pillow, and the young adult I'm becoming. You remember all of them and love each one without question.

Sometimes I try to picture You in heaven, atop a golden throne with angels around You praising and glorifying You, but honestly, I see You better here. On that porch in the dim afternoon light. Never ceasing to look down that road. So when I imagine God, I imagine You, the One on the porch, the Father with the soft, long beard and big belly laugh, the warm presence who waits faithfully for me to come home to Him every day. The One who always sees me first.

The One on the Porch
— Benmet Yiesak '26

To me You are an old and wise man with a soft white beard and caramel skin, the kind who rocks on a wooden porch facing a quiet country road. Even before I reach the road, You've already seen me, my tired shoulders, the burden I try to

The Unusual Refugee – Siennie Assegid '29

The humble dove,
pure in spirit,
steadfast in tranquility,
herald of peace,
symbol of innocence.

But what if the dove isn't innocent?
What if the dove is a witness of destruction?
An observer of violence,
desperately attempting to flee.

Constantly being displaced,
moving from place to place,
searching for respite.

Maybe that's why doves live everywhere,
they can never find a place to stay.
Bombs will always fall,
shots will always ring,
the humble dove will attempt to leave,
and so will we.



Sydney Townsend '26



Jacob Cruz '27

Aren't We Getting Bored? — Hoa Ngo '29

A child tells her mother,
"Take me to the store, I want a new toy!
I've played with mine too much, I'm bored."
Her mother shakes her head,
saying there is no need to go,
"There are children with no food,
children with no home."
The child turns away, upset.

But isn't her mother right?
The saying's just overused.
Overused to say children starve,
overused to say they have no home,
so overused that suffering has become common,
so common that we no longer care.
We would love to help,
But it's pushed into our faces, begging for aid.
Aren't we getting bored?

We keep our head down when we pass a beggar,
we choose not to add 60 cents for breast cancer.
How can we let them suffer?
How can we ignore their cries?

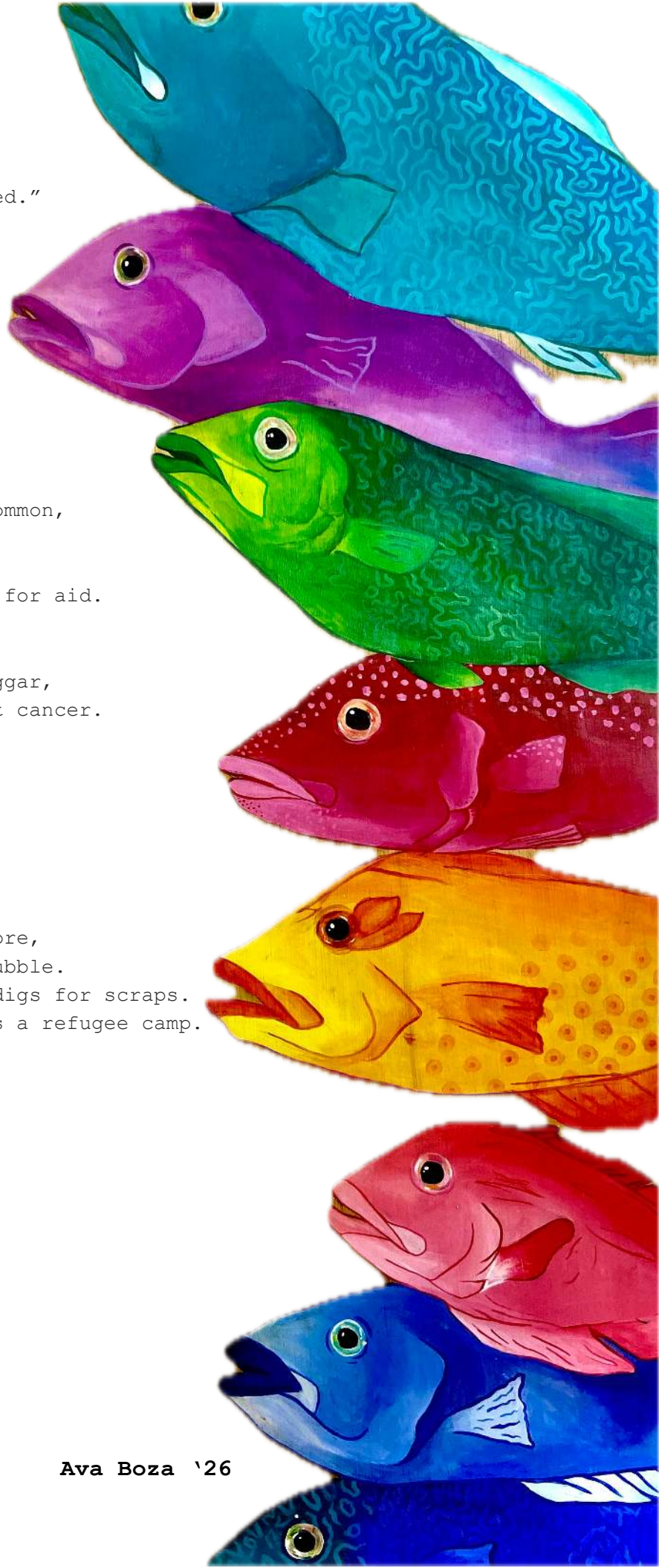
But we have our own lives, right?
We would love to help,
but aren't we getting bored?

So while our mothers drive us to the store,
another searches for her child in the rubble.
While we feast on a warm meal, someone digs for scraps.
And when we arrive home, a family enters a refugee camp.

How can we live like this?
With everything at our fingertips,
while others break their nails,
scavenging for what's left.

But people still suffer, don't they?
Everyday, homes in Gaza are bombed,
everyday, children in the Congo starve,
everyday civilians in Tigray are raped,
so what's another day?

Besides, that's their life, not ours,
and we care, of course we do.
But aren't we getting bored?



The Oldest in the Room – Tessa Majchrzak '26

Suddenly I was the oldest in the room,
And I can't separate the excitement from the gloom.
I know I am growing, but nostalgia is haunting me out of tune.
Suddenly I was the oldest in the room,
No more Barbies, or make-believe place,
Now I'm setting timers for deadlines and praying for some grace.
I wait for a button to just rewind,
But I knew that it was all just a matter of time.
Anticipation for the future, overshadowed by bitterness of the past.
The next chapter is looming, and consuming me fast.
There is no time to take a pause
while I'm waiting for the applause.

Ava Gill '27

As I walk those last steps.
And suddenly I'm in a different room,
no longer the oldest,
but someone younger takes my view.



Like Us – Kellie Gilliam '26

"Y'all have your mother's hair," Ms. Lynn says as she gathers mine into a clip. "Same waves," she says.

What had been isolated instances in my likes and dislikes, looks and style, became visible heredity and decades-built tradition when the family got together. My cousins and I share the family nose. Mama's brother, who started graying at West Point, may one day grow Great Uncle's head of thick white hair. My brother's hair outstretches into a kind of 'fro; he's destined to keep ground cover all his life. Great Aunt maintains a high-side ponytail, 80's style, and her long coils that rain down from a single scrunchie.

This doesn't happen every day.

There are talkers and quiet ones. Generosity and sacrifice rivals only the strong, demolish-all-limits work ethic, a lasting lesson from the farming days. It is scientifically impossible for us to get through meal prep without nibbling. We gather together, online or in person, a circle of bowed heads, both closed and open eyes, to pray. Every now and again, the prayer of one person, a race if you will, becomes a relay.

"Father, in the name of Jesus," Mama starts.

After a while her mother grabs the reigns, turning the thanks and petition in a new direction.

We all say, "Amen," and leave it at that.

This doesn't happen everywhere.

I find out that so many of us are teachers. That my older cousin wrote for her college newspaper. That she and her mother are close, like my mom and I. When you really think about it, having so many wonderful people in one family is an amazing occurrence. An act of God, one might say.

I'm glad it happened to us.

The Year Called Senior Year — Jaelyn Escobar '26

Looking up at the sky, what do I see?
Another year beginning for me.
Father God,
please walk beside me
as I start my final year at SJC.

I've made new friends and grown so much,
found comfort in laughter and faith's gentle touch.
But deep inside, I can already feel
the year slipping forward, almost too real.

The pressure builds, college apps and plans,
essays and deadlines stacked in my hands.
Some days I'm confident, ready to go,
other days I'm unsure of what I know.

There's frustration and indecision too,
but I try to stay grounded and look to You.
Because even when my path's not clear,
I trust You'll guide me through this year.

The future is coming, but I'm not done,
we just started, there's still more lessons, laughter, and fun.
It definitely won't be easy, but it's all a part of me —
this final chapter at SJC.



Ave Boza '26

Victory Jones '27



The Family – Liam Kilroy '29

It is 2149 and the monarchy has been back in the states for 79 years now. There has not been a presidential election since 2075. Sure, there has been an election every few years, but there is never a candidate to run against The Family. Whenever someone even considered running against them, they ended up serving a life sentence without parole or turning into a missing person's case. Some of us saw this coming, but not enough of us to stop it. The Family told the people what they wanted to hear, took advantage of the uninformed, and won the election before they could be stopped. This week, there is going to be another rally in the capital, just a way to show The Family's power and make sure that the people remain in line, so attendance is obviously mandatory – because if you say no, then they assume you are protesting them or trying to put the “wrong ideas” into people's minds. Everyone is sent an invitation, however invitations are really just a formality. Everyone knows that they have to say yes, and so we all do, at least until this week.

(cont.)

Kira Younger '29



(cont.)

In an act of pure stupidity, I replied no, because I did not feel like being at an event celebrating the most horrid ideals known to humankind. I'm exhausted by it all. I presumed they received my message, because the guards came to my home and asked me to come with them for some "light questioning."

When we arrived at the building, I was escorted in by three guards, each armed with a different weapon, all of which were enough to kill me in one



Emery Tomeldon '27

strike. Had I really committed a crime? All of a sudden I started to shake uncontrollably, as if I wasn't shaking on my own, but someone else was shaking me. Is this it? I thought. Am I dying?

Suddenly, my eyes opened. My brother was shaking me awake, wanting me to help him with the television. The election of 2075 is still two weeks away, and I hadn't yet responded to the invitation. I did however learn something from this nightmare. If I do not speak up, if I do not fight for the truth, then I will be

part of the greatest crime of them all: when people who consider themselves good, don't speak out against what is wrong. If I do not fight against this power-driven, oppressive monster with every fiber of my being, then I am not just hurting myself, I am hurting the whole world, and I will not make that mistake.

It was a dark, early morning and my dad was driving me to my dawn-workout at St. John's. Just as we were entering the dense, foggy forest of Rock Creek Park, my dad remembered some of the folklore from his childhood in Guatemala. He lowered his voice: "Have you heard about La Llorona?"

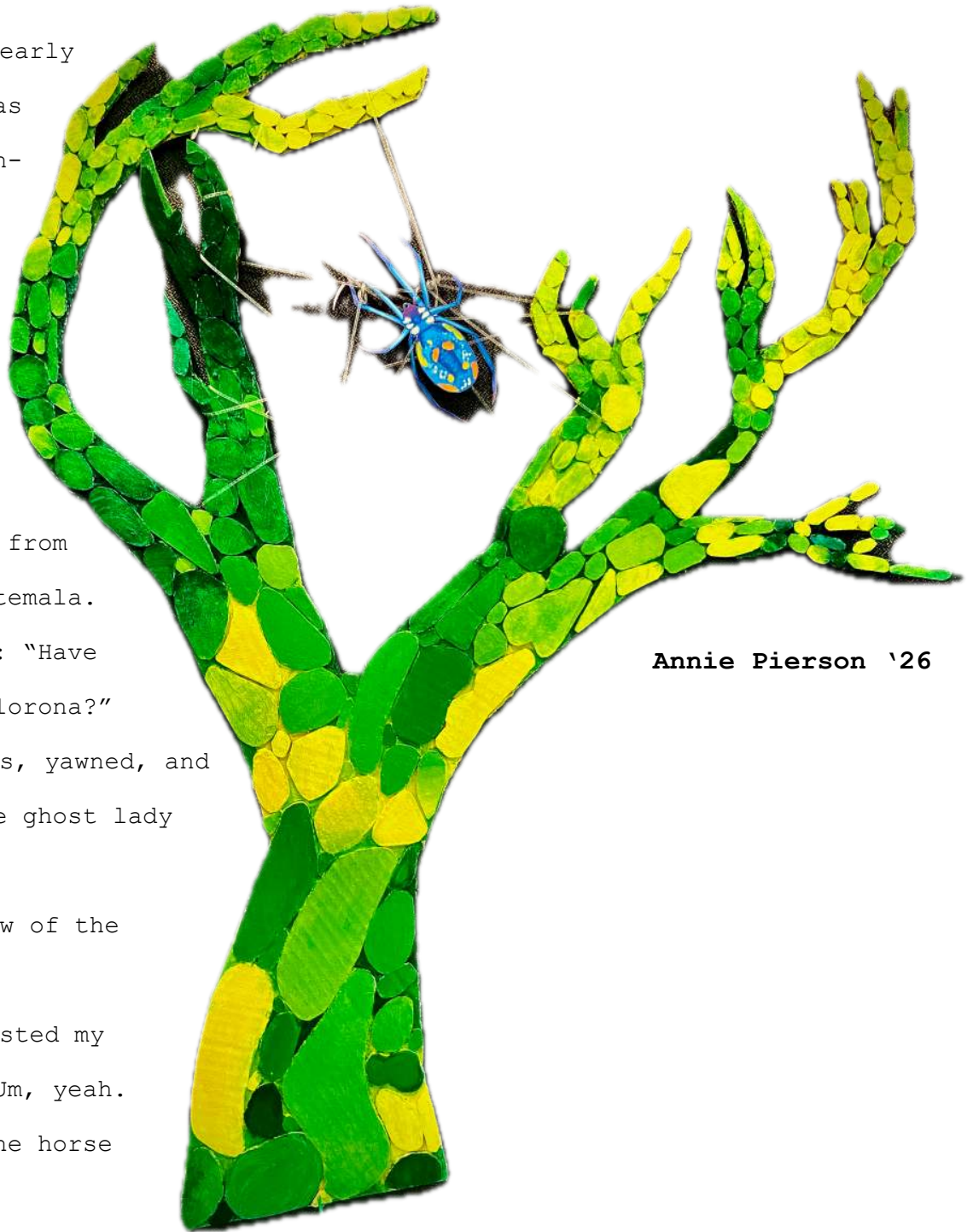
I rolled my eyes, yawned, and said, "Yeah, it's the ghost lady that wails."

"But do you know of the Siguanaba?"

Then, as I adjusted my shoe, I responded, "Um, yeah. It's the lady with the horse face."

For a moment, my dad went silent. Until, all of a sudden, he began, "Mijo, have you heard about EL CADEJO?" I made a face, mildly curious as to what this Cadejo thing was; so my dad continued. "You know, a long time ago, in one of the darker towns in Guatemala, your abuelita was talking with a neighbor and decided to walk her home since there were not many street lights at that time. All of a sudden, she started feeling head pains and asked her neighbor whether she was feeling odd, too. Before she could answer,

(cont.)



Annie Pierson '26

(cont.)

her neighbor noticed an innocent little street dog sitting next to them. Trying to ignore the dog, your abuela's neighbor fearfully whispered that they need to just keep on moving, but the dog followed them." He paused for effect.

"They both got to the neighbor's house safely and once they entered, the neighbor told her the story of El Cadejo. It is a spirit that tests people's true natures. It disguises itself as a simple stray dog and roams around dark streets. She said that if you kick or mistreat the dog, it will possess your mind and cause you to throw yourself off of one of the many barrancos (ravines) in the area. On the other hand, her neighbor continued, if you are nice to El Cadejo, he will guarantee that you will get home safely."

The story gave me a chill, and all I could do was stare out into the dense fog. A strange presence from outside of the car began to grow. Peering as hard as I could, suddenly a distant pair of glowing eyes stared right back at me from the wooded abyss. They disappeared just as quickly. I shook it off and didn't really think much about those piercing eyes, until we finally emerged from the foggy twilight and reached the soft-glowing campus. With a pat on the back, my dad told

me "Have a great day, mijo!" As his car drove back into the eerie gloom of Rock Creek Park, and I felt alone, I I couldn't help but wonder: Was that just a deer, or was that El Cadejo?



Courtney Bliley '26

